

DEBAJYOTI CHAKRABORTY

GAME FOR A FIGHT
Mamata, in a wheelchair, at an election rally in Nischinda, Howrah district, April 2021

with strategist Prashant Kishor and nephew Abhishek Banerjee, began revamping the TMC and tweaking welfare packages to reach every strata of Bengal's 100 million electorate. Yet, it was a daunting challenge. The saffron camp were firing on all cylinders and—at the peak of the campaign—deputed 70 national leaders, including Union ministers and chief ministers, on its '*Ebar Bangla* (Now Bengal)' mission. Prime Minister Narendra Modi himself made 18 forays while Amit Shah crisscrossed the state 20 times.

Mamata faced it all squarely, even the staggered election over eight phases. It was a closely monitored poll. The Election Commission had deployed 700-1,000 companies of paramilitary for each phase, shunted over two dozen top state police officers, rummaged through her comfort zone of security personnel by transferring the director general of security after an alleged attack on her in Nandigram and even barred her from campaigning for a day.

None of this cowed down Didi—least of all the ankle fracture suffered in Nandigram, where she narrowly lost to protégé-turned-foe Suvendu Adhikari. Ignoring medical advice, she returned to campaign—in a wheelchair. Juggling a football (Bengal's favourite sport) at a rally, Mamata declared "*Khela hobe* (Game is on)", and inspired many a meme. "Mamata's connect with the masses transcends elections. She has not assumed an aura of inaccessibility or leader-like superiority and distanced herself from the people," says Jawhar Sircar, Rajya Sabha MP and former Prasar Bharati CEO. "Her welfare schemes have evolved from her close association with people at the grassroots and an understanding of their needs."

If opponents had hoped that pressure tactics by way of sending central agencies after TMC leaders would work in the polls, Mamata hit back with a vengeance. The Enforcement Directorate (ED) came knocking on Abhishek's door and questioned his wife Rujira over alleged money laundering. The BJP cried corruption,

MAMATA'S HIGHS...

- Mamata's landslide win against the PM Modi and Amit Shah-led BJP—money, manpower, machinations proved to be no match for Mamata's might and magic
- A leg fracture during the polls couldn't break Didi's spirit. Football in hand, the wheelchair-bound Mamata became a symbol of *Khela Hobe*. It signalled to rivals that she was very much in the game
- She has risen in stature within the Opposition as a credible challenger to Narendra Modi in the 2024 Lok Sabha poll. Many Congress, BJP, JD(U), NCP and AAP leaders have gravitated towards her
- The TMC is exploring turfs beyond Bengal, beginning with BJP-ruled Tripura, Goa and Haryana
- Few leaders can match Mamata's welfarism, costing Rs 25,000 crore a year. She brought governance delivery to people's doorstep and is giving business and investment a big push to create 15 million jobs

...AND LOWS

- Lost an election for the first time in her political career—to former protégé Suvendu Adhikari in Nandigram. Later, won the Bhabanipur assembly bypoll
- Unable to restrain hooligans in the party, who have been accused by the Opposition of rigging the recent Kolkata civic body elections
- TMC failed to implement one man-one post convention as Mamata continues to reward loyalists with multiple roles
- Critics say her populist schemes are a drain on the exchequer at a time when the state is in deep financial crisis